A DOCTORAL THESIS

MMXXVI

ON DANNY BOYLE AND ALEX GARLAND'S FILM OF 2002

HELL/



Lyssa, Immunity, and Phatic Anthropogenesis in Danny Boyle and Alex Garland's 28 Days Later

SEVEN CHAPTERS · AN INTRODUCTION · A CONCLUSION

TWENTY-EIGHT DAYS

ONE LUNAR MONTH



The opposite of contagion is not immunity; it is address.

THESIS IV · PHATIC ANTHROPOGENESIS

SUMMARY OF THE ARGUMENT

Abstract

This thesis argues that Danny Boyle and Alex Garland's 28 *Days Later* (2002) is not a zombie film but a nosology of violence: a clinical fiction that isolates rage as a transmissible substance in order to test, one by one, the institutions that claim to contain it. Romero's dead consume; Garland's Infected neither die nor eat, but transmit. That substitution of communication for consumption moves the genre from eschatology to nosology, and from the question of what survives the end of the world to the question of what, once institutions fail, may still be called human. Drawing on classical philology, political philosophy, evolutionary primatology, psychoanalysis, and a comparative corpus that runs from the *Iliad*, Euripides, and the *Táin Bó Cúailnge* to Wyndham, Romero, Kafka, and the film's own sequels, the thesis advances four claims.

First, the film's Rage recovers the Homeric *lyssa*, the "wolfish" battle-frenzy whose name now classifies the rabies genus, and stages a *lyssic indistinction* between pathology and agency that culminates when Selena cannot tell Jim's heroic fury from infection. Second, the film articulates a taxonomy of violences—reactive, immunitary, proactive-sovereign, heroic—whose most disturbing finding, corroborated by Richard Wrangham's distinction between reactive and proactive aggression, is that organized horror belongs exclusively to the uninfected; in the virus itself it identifies a *replicative violence* for which Walter Benjamin's typology of law-making, law-preserving, and divine violence has no name. Third, Selena's rule of killing an infected companion "in a heartbeat" adopts the virus's own ten-to-twenty-second tempo and enacts, at the scale of the survivor band, the immunitary logic Roberto Esposito diagnoses in modern sovereignty; Major West's compound completes that logic as autoimmunity, and the revelation of Britain's quarantine turns Gaunt's island "fortress … / Against infection" into the world's lazaretto, a *reverse quarantine*. Fourth, against immunity the film proposes not cure but address. The thesis names this proposal *phatic anthropogenesis*: the human appears neither as species, bloodline, nor polity, but as a renewable act of greeting that suspends decision (the Senecan *mora*), accepts exposure (a bloodied kiss that repeats Theseus's touch of the polluted Heracles), and calls an unknown other without condition. Its emblem is the final image, in which the word HELL is completed by a vocative O.

The opposite of contagion, the thesis concludes, is not immunity but address. Contagion is transmission that abolishes the other by converting it into the same; address is transmission that preserves the other as other, which is why the answer to the survivors' HELLO arrives in Finnish. Read in this light, the film moves from the Iliadic economy of plague, wrath, and women seized in an armed camp to the Odyssean economy of waking on an unrecognized shore, testing the stranger, and weaving; and its time is lunar rather than apocalyptic, measured by a twenty-eight-day month, a sleeper woken twice, and a heroine named for the moon. A conclusion situates the film at the head of a *lyssic cinema* distinct from the zombie tradition and traces the argument through the franchise and its authors' later work.

THE ORDER OF THE ARGUMENT

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INTRODUCTION

NOSOLOGY AS METHOD

FOUR THESES

I *Lyssic indistinction*

II *A taxonomy of violences*

III *Immunity becomes autoimmunity*

IV *Phatic anthropogenesis*

i. The objectless rage

28 DAYS LATER begins where the classical theory of anger ends: with an affect that has lost its object. Aristotle defined *orgē* as a pained desire for conspicuous revenge upon a particular person for a particular slight (*Rhetoric* 2.2), and held that anger, unlike hatred, is always directed at individuals (2.4). The virus that escapes a Cambridge primate laboratory in the film's prologue keeps every somatic sign of that passion—the flooded face, the bared teeth, the eyes that blaze and flash in Seneca's portrait of the angry man (*De Ira* 1.1.4)—while abolishing its intentional structure. The Infected hold no grievance and remember no injury; their only target is the nearest uninfected body. They do not eat, as Romero's dead eat, and they have not died, as Romero's dead have died. In the strict sense they do not even attack, since attack presupposes a reason that might have counselled otherwise. They transmit. A drop of blood or saliva suffices, and within ten to twenty seconds the recipient becomes a transmitter in turn. What the film calls Rage is anger reduced to pure communicability: a passion that wants nothing except its own reproduction in another.

That reduction is the film's method. By isolating rage as a substance, separable from persons and transmissible between them, Garland's screenplay performs on violence the operation that eighteenth-century medicine performed on fever. François Boissier de Sauvages's *Nosologia methodica* (1763) sorted diseases into classes, orders, and genera as Linnaeus sorted plants; a nosology treats a disorder as a species whose characters can be observed apart from the sufferer (Foucault 1963). The film treats violence the same way. It cultures rage, incubates it, quarantines it, and—as the laboratory's scientist hopes—seeks to understand it before curing it. This thesis takes the film at its methodological word and reads it as a nosology of violence: a fiction that distills rage into an agent in order to observe, under experimental conditions, what each human institution does in its presence. The laboratory, the screen, the metropolis, the household, the survivor band, the military compound, and the island nation are each tested by the agent, and each, in the film's diagnostic sequence, reproduces the violence it claims to contain. The horror is not that normality is threatened by the monster, the formula in which Robin Wood (1979) condensed the American horror film. It is that the institutions of normality prove to be the monster's most efficient hosts.

ii. Corpus and variorum

The primary object is the theatrical release (United Kingdom, 1 November 2002; United States, 27 June 2003), produced by Andrew Macdonald for DNA Films, written by Alex Garland, directed by Danny Boyle, and photographed principally on Canon XL1 digital video by Anthony Dod Mantle. Unusually for a commercial feature, the film also exists as a variorum. Its home-video editions preserve a filmed alternate ending, in which Jim dies of his gunshot wound in an abandoned hospital, and a storyboarded "radical alternative" that dispenses with the military compound and resolves the plot through a total blood transfusion paid for with Jim's life. These are treated here as rejected hypotheses, the paths whose exclusion defines the path taken. A film that considered ending in exhaustion, and then in sacrificial blood, and chose instead to end with a word, is making an argument; the alternates are its drafts, and their rejection is evidence.

The corpus extends outward in three rings. The first is the franchise: *28 Weeks Later* (2007), *28 Years Later* (2025), and *28 Years Later: The Bone Temple* (2026), which revisit the original's premises under altered political conditions. The second is the authors' wider work, from Garland's novel *The Coma* (2004) to his films as director and Boyle's later features. The third is a comparative archive of plague, frenzy, and catastrophe narratives that runs from the *Iliad* to *Pontypool* (2008).

iii. Influence, tradition, constellation

Three relations to prior texts must be kept distinct. The first is influence in the strict sense: sources whose traces are acknowledged or unmistakable. These include John Wyndham's *The Day of the Triffids* (1951), whose hero wakes in a hospital bed to a silent London; George A. Romero's outbreak film *The Crazies* (1973) and his *Day of the Dead* (1985), with its chained ghoul and psychotic military enclave; *A Clockwork Orange* in Burgess's novel (1962) and Kubrick's film (1971); Conrad's *Heart of Darkness* (1899) by way of Coppola's *Apocalypse Now* (1979); and the British catastrophe tradition from Wells to the BBC's nuclear docudramas. The second relation is tradition: deep structures of plague, wrath, and hospitality that the film inherits whether or not its makers had them in mind—Homeric epic, Attic tragedy, Irish saga, Stoic ethics, biblical covenant. The third relation, the one this thesis invokes most often, is what Walter Benjamin called the constellation. In the "Epistemo-Critical Prologue" to his study of the German *Trauerspiel* (1928), Benjamin proposed that ideas are to phenomena as constellations are to stars: neither cause nor source, but a configuration in which scattered points become legible as a figure that none contains alone. When this thesis sets Selena's machete beside Penelope's loom,

or Major West's dinner table beside the hall of Odysseus's suitors, it makes no claim about Garland's reading. It claims that the film's figure becomes visible when these stars are joined.

The method declines the intentional fallacy (Wimsatt and Beardsley 1946) in both directions. It neither restricts meaning to what the authors intended nor treats documented intentions as irrelevant. Boyle's Catholic upbringing, Garland's fluency in science fiction and video games, and the economics of British independent production are facts; they constrain interpretation without exhausting it.

iv. Four theses

Thesis I: lyssic indistinction. The film's Rage recovers the Greek *lyssa*, the "wolfish" battle-frenzy that enters Hector and holds Achilles, which Euripides personified as a reluctant goddess and which modern virology preserved in the name of the rabies genus, *Lyssavirus*. *Lyssa* names a condition in which pathology and agency cannot be told apart: the warrior in frenzy is at once hero and patient. The film builds toward a scene that makes this literal, when Selena, machete raised, cannot tell whether the blood-soaked Jim is infected or merely enraged. The adjective *lyssic* is proposed here for violence that is undecidable between disease and deed.

Thesis II: a taxonomy of violences. The film distributes violence among four bearers: the reactive, impulsive aggression of the Infected, derived from chimpanzees; the immunitary, pre-emptive killing prescribed by Selena's early rule; the proactive, coalitionary, sovereign violence of West's soldiers; and the heroic frenzy of Jim's return. Read against Richard Wrangham's distinction between reactive and proactive aggression (2019), the taxonomy yields the film's most disturbing finding: the virus produces chaos, but organized horror—execution, planned rape, the hunting of dissenters—belongs exclusively to the sane. The virus itself embodies a fifth mode absent from Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921). Neither law-making nor law-preserving nor divine, it is *replicative*: a violence whose only end is its own reproduction.

Thesis III: immunity becomes autoimmunity. Selena's rule that an infected companion must be killed "in a heartbeat" compresses the instant of decision to the virus's own incubation, so that the defense against Rage acquires Rage's tempo. Roberto Esposito's account of *immunitas*, the protection of life through its negation (2002), describes the rule exactly. Jacques Derrida's account of autoimmunity (1996; 2003) describes its outcome in West's compound, which keeps an Infected soldier chained in its yard as a living antigen and is destroyed from within. The late revelation that Britain has been quarantined inverts the island's founding fantasy. Gaunt's "fortress built by Nature for herself / Against infection and the hand of war" (*Richard II* 2.1.43–44) has become the world's

lazaretto, sealed to keep infection in rather than out. This thesis calls the inversion *reverse quarantine*.

Thesis IV: phatic anthropogenesis. Against immunity, the film proposes neither cure nor vaccine but address. Its resolution depends on three counter-reflexes: the suspended decision (Selena's hesitation, the *mora* that Seneca called the greatest remedy of anger); the accepted exposure (the bloodied kiss, which repeats Theseus's refusal of pollution in Euripides' *Heracles* and enacts Esposito's *communitas*); and the unconditioned address (HELLO, laid out in cloth for an unknown reader in the sky). On this account the human is neither a species, a bloodline, nor a polity; it is a renewable act of greeting. The central formula follows: the opposite of contagion is not immunity; it is address. Contagion is transmission that abolishes the other by making it the same. Address is transmission that preserves the other as other—and so the reply, when it comes, comes in Finnish.

Two structural claims frame these theses. The first is epic. The film moves from the economy of the *Iliad*'s first book—a plague provoked by violated sanctity, a quarrel over women held as prizes in an armed camp—to the economy of the *Odyssey*'s second half: a sleeper waking on an unrecognized shore, a house usurped by armed men, a violent homecoming, a wife's testing hesitation, a woman at her loom. The second claim is temporal. The film's time is lunar rather than apocalyptic. Its title names a lunar month; its hero wakes twice; its heroine bears the moon's name; and its ending is not an end but the turn of a cycle, a structure the franchise has literalized by recurring at twenty-eight weeks and twenty-eight years.

> *"The film's time is lunar rather than apocalyptic.*

v. Plan of the work

Chapter One reconstructs the philology of rage from Homeric *mēnis* and *lyssa* through Euripides, Irish and Norse frenzy, Stoic and Aristotelian ethics, and the medical history of rabies, and argues that the film's decisive innovation is the abolition of incubation. Chapter Two reads the prologue's chimpanzee and screens through Kubrick, British media-effects panics, the animal-liberation movement, primatology, media theory, and Girard, and formulates replicative violence. Chapter Three follows Jim through emptied London, situating the sleeper-device and the city's silences within the Last Man tradition and the theory of phatic communion. Chapter Four analyzes Selena's rule through

Esposito, Schmitt, Agamben, and Derrida. Chapter Five treats West's compound as the convergence of a long genealogy of armed camps and reproductive emergencies. Chapter Six reads the climax as a *ríastrad*, a hero's warp-spasm, whose resolution depends on a look and a kiss. Chapter Seven reads the ending—the second waking, the sewing, the HELL completed by O, and the Finnish reply—as the formal statement of phatic anthropogenesis. A conclusion defines a lyssic cinema distinct from the zombie film and follows the argument into the franchise and its authors' later work.

CHAPTER ONE

LYSSA

A Philology of Rage

> *Nulla pestis humano generi pluris stetit.* (“No plague has cost the human race more.”)
>
> SENECA, *DE IRA* 1.2.1, ON ANGER

01



The film's Rage is not a modern invention dressed in virology but the return of an ancient category that virology itself had already named. This chapter recovers that category, *lyssa*, and argues that the film's one decisive innovation is temporal: it removes the interval in which every earlier culture managed frenzy.

1.1 Mēnis and lyssa

EUROPEAN literature begins with rage. The first word of the *Iliad* is *mēnin*, the accusative of *mēnis*, and Peter Sloterdijk (2006) built a political psychology of *thymos* on that opening. Homer, however, distinguishes kinds of fury with a precision later theory lost. *Mēnis*, as Leonard Muellner (1996) showed, is a cosmic sanction: a wrath proper to gods and, among mortals, to Achilles alone, provoked when the order of honor is violated and resolved when that order is repaired. It has a cause (Agamemnon's dishonor), an object (the Achaeans), a duration (until Patroclus dies), and an end (the ransom of Hector's body). *Lyssa* is another thing. Odysseus says of Hector that strong *lyssa* has entered him (*Il.* 9.239); later, *lyssa* holds the heart of Achilles as he drives the Trojans toward their walls (21.542–43). Teucer, failing to hit Hector, calls him a raging dog, *kuna lyssētēra* (8.299). Bruce Lincoln (1975) derived the word from *lykos*, "wolf," and glossed it as "wolfish rage." The verb Homer uses at 9.239, *dedūke*, is the verb of putting on armor and of sinking into a body; *lyssa* is something a warrior dons and something that enters him. Equipment and infection share a verb.

The distinction clarifies the film's economy. The Infected are *lyssa* without a warrior: frenzy detached from aristeia, honor, and name, made anonymous and democratic. Homer never imagined *lyssa* without a hero to inhabit; the film imagines nothing else for its first two acts, and in its third returns *lyssa* to a hero and asks whether the difference still holds. The *Iliad*'s opening also supplies the film's first structure. Apollo Smintheus—the "mouse god," whose epithet many scholars connect with plague-bearing rodents—sends nine days of plague into the Achaean camp because Agamemnon has refused to return the daughter of his priest. The consequence of the plague is a quarrel over women held as prizes, as Agamemnon takes Briseis from Achilles. Plague first, then the traffic in women among armed men: the *Iliad*'s first book is the film's first two acts in compressed form. Even the rats that stream through the tunnel ahead of the Infected on the road north belong to this archive. In the film the rodent no longer carries plague; it flees ahead of it, a herald rather than a vector.

> *Equipment and infection share a verb.*

1.2 The reluctant goddess

The fullest ancient anatomy of *lyssa* is Euripides' *Heracles* (c. 416 BCE). Hera sends Iris and Lyssa, daughter of Night and of the blood of Ouranos, to madden the hero on his return from the underworld. Lyssa then does something no other Greek personification of violence does: she objects. She protests that Heracles has served gods and men and urges restraint, until Iris retorts that Hera did not send her in order to be sensible. The goddess of frenzy is the only character in the scene who argues for moderation. Her reluctance matters, because it locates *lyssa* outside the will of its bearer and also outside the will of its agent. Frenzy here is pure transmission, an errand performed under protest.

The messenger's speech then gives a clinical picture that a neurologist might sign: rolling, bloodshot eyes and foam running into the hero's beard. Believing he is killing the children of Eurystheus, Heracles kills his own sons and his wife Megara. Athena strikes him unconscious with a stone, and he wakes bound to a pillar, not knowing what he has done. The play's final movement turns from frenzy to pollution (on *miasma*, see Parker 1983). Heracles veils his head so that the blood-guilt clinging to him will not infect his friend Theseus. Theseus uncovers him and grasps his hand, declaring that no avenging spirit passes from friend to friend (1234), and offers him refuge in Athens. This is the first of the thesis's three counter-reflexes in its classical form. The bound sleeper wakes from frenzy; the friend refuses the logic of contagion and touches him anyway. Chapters Six and Seven will show the film restaging both gestures.

1.3 Ríastrad and berserksgangr

Irish saga offers frenzy as metamorphosis. In the *Táin Bó Cúailnge* Cú Chulainn's *ríastrad*—rendered "warp-spasm" in Thomas Kinsella's translation (1969)—twists his body inside its skin, sucks one eye deep into his skull while the other bulges onto his cheek, and sends a column of dark blood up from his crown. The most revealing episode comes from his boyhood deeds. Returning to Emain Macha still in battle-fury, the boy threatens the Ulstermen themselves, who send out the women of the court, bare-breasted, to meet him. He averts his eyes; the warriors seize him and plunge him into three vats of cold water. The first bursts, the second boils, and only the third grows bearably

warm. Heroic frenzy is managed here not by force but by an interruption that is at once erotic, maternal, and aqueous, and by the hero's own averted gaze. The film's resolution will turn on a woman, a look, and a storm.

Norse tradition names the same condition as a social institution. Snorri's *Ynglinga saga* (ch. 6, c. 1230) describes Odin's warriors going into battle without mail, mad as dogs or wolves, biting their shields, strong as bears or bulls, untouched by fire or iron: this, Snorri says, is called *berserksgangr*. The *úlfheðnar*, "wolf-coats," complete the zoology. Georges Dumézil (1970) read such figures as the dangerous energy of the warrior function, which must be ritually reintegrated when the warrior comes home; his paradigm is Horatius, who returns victorious from single combat, kills his own sister, and must pass beneath a beam set across the road before Rome can receive him (Livy 1.26). Jonathan Shay's clinical work with Vietnam veterans (1994) supplies the modern pathology: the "berserk state" is triggered by a commander's betrayal of what is right and by the death of a special comrade. The berserker, Shay insists, is not a type of man but an injured one. Every element of that etiology—betrayal by command, the loss of a comrade, the return to a household that cannot receive the returning fighter—recurs in the film's final act.

1.4 Brevis insania

Seneca's *De Ira* is the decisive classical text, because it treats anger as a disease with symptoms, a course, and a regimen. Some wise men, he writes, have called anger a brief madness (1.1.2), and his portrait of its signs reads like a description of the Infected: the eyes blaze and flash, the whole face floods crimson with blood surging from the heart, the lips tremble, the teeth clench, the hair bristles (1.1.3–4). He calls anger a plague in the epidemiological sense—no plague has cost the human race more (1.2.1)—and refuses the Peripatetic view that anger, moderated, serves courage. His evidence is military. The Germans are the freest and fiercest of peoples, he argues, yet disciplined Romans defeat them, because reason outlasts fury (1.11). Major West's cold soldiers are Seneca's disciplined legion. The film reverses Seneca's verdict: Jim's fury defeats the disciplined men, though only by allying itself with the disease.

Seneca's remedy is temporal. The greatest remedy of anger is delay, *maximum remedium irae mora est* (2.29.1; compare 3.12.4), because anger's first impulses are violent and subside if made to wait. Horace compressed the doctrine into a line: *ira furor brevis est*, anger is a brief madness; rule the mind, which commands unless it obeys (*Epistles* 1.2.62–63). Every later remedy for frenzy—the vats of water, Theseus's patience, Penelope's unwoven web—is a technology of *mora*. The film's virus is designed to make *mora* impossible.

Aristotle supplies two further instruments. The first is a simile. Anger, he says in the *Nicomachean Ethics*, hears reason but mishears it, like servants who run off before hearing the whole instruction, or like dogs that bark at a knock before looking to see whether the visitor is a friend (7.6, 1149a25–b3). The barking dog is the exact structure of Selena's early rule, and the look before the bark is exactly what she achieves in the climax. The second instrument is a definition. Anger, for Aristotle, wants to be known by its object: the angry man wishes his victim to perceive who punished him and why, and the *Rhetoric* cites as evidence Odysseus shouting his own name back at the blinded Cyclops (2.3, 1380b; *Od.* 9.502–5). Anger in this sense is a perverse form of address. The Infected abolish even that. Their fury wants no recognition and calls no name. The film thus traces a full arc of address: from a Rage that addresses no one, through a sovereign who addresses only to capture, to a greeting that addresses anyone.

1.5 From hydrophobia to Lyssavirus

Rabies is the oldest regulated rage. The Laws of Eshnunna (§56, early second millennium BCE) make the owner of a mad dog liable if the authorities have warned him and the dog kills a man. Aristotle held that dogs suffer from *lyssa* and that every animal they bite contracts it except man (*History of Animals* 8.22, 604a)—an exemption the film revokes, since its premise is that the human is the most susceptible animal of all. Celsus called hydrophobia the most wretched of diseases, in which the patient is tormented at once by thirst and by dread of water, and recommended throwing him unawares into a pool (*De Medicina* 5.27). The film inverts the symptom. Its uninfected are defined by thirst: Jim's first act in the deserted city is to drink, Frank and Hannah set buckets out for rain because their water has run out, and the climax unfolds in a downpour. Rage is the condition that water does not reach.

Modern immunology begins with rabies. On 6 July 1885 Louis Pasteur began a course of injections of attenuated rabies material in Joseph Meister, a nine-year-old Alsatian boy bitten two days earlier; the boy lived. Vaccination, the founding gesture of the immunitary paradigm examined in Chapter Four, introduces a weakened fragment of the disease in order to protect against it. The rabies genus was later named *Lyssavirus*, closing a circle from Homer's battlefield to the laboratory. Juan Gómez-Alonso (1998) argued that rabies, with its insomnia, aggression, aversion to water and mirrors, and transmission by bite, underlies the vampire legends that spread through eighteenth-century Eastern Europe during epizootics among dogs and wolves. Lycanthropy belongs to the same complex. Ovid's Lycaon, who tests Jupiter's divinity by serving him human flesh, is turned into a wolf for violating the god's hospitality, and his crime moves Jupiter to destroy the human race by flood (*Metamorphoses* 1.163–261). Wolfishness, violated hospitality, and deluge form a

single mythic sequence, which the film reassembles in West's house and the storm that breaks over it. David Cronenberg's *Rabid* (1977) had already returned the outbreak film to this root, as victims foaming and raging spread a bite-borne frenzy through Montreal until martial law is declared. By making its monster a living carrier rather than a revenant, *28 Days Later* returns the vampire, the werewolf, and the zombie to their common zoonotic origin.

1.6 The incubation of ten seconds

Clinical rabies incubates for weeks or months. That latency is the horror of the classical disease and also its mercy, since it opens the interval in which diagnosis, care, and Pasteur's treatment become possible. The film abolishes it. Its incubation of ten to twenty seconds removes the space in which judgment, quarantine, and grief could occur. Paul Virilio's dromology (1977) argued that the speed of modern vectors compresses the interval in which politics takes place, and that every technology invents its own accident: to invent the ship is to invent the shipwreck (2005). Jim's backstory belongs to that order. He was a bicycle courier, a laborer of urban speed, knocked down by a car; his coma removed him from speed for exactly the period in which speed became pathological.

The formal consequence is generic. Romero's dead are slow, and their slowness creates the siege: the boarded farmhouse of *Night of the Living Dead* (1968), the shopping mall of *Dawn of the Dead* (1978), and the long quarrels inside both. Running monsters existed before 2002—Umberto Lenzi's *Nightmare City* (1980), Dan O'Bannon's *The Return of the Living Dead* (1985)—but *28 Days Later* made speed the genre's grammar, provoking Simon Pegg's (2008) objection that the dead should not run. The film's implicit reply is that its creatures are not dead. Speed changes architecture. Where slowness permits the fortress, speed compels flight, and the only place in the film where humans again have time is West's fortified house—where they use it to plan rape. Thesis I can now be stated formally. Violence is *lyssic* when it occurs below the threshold of the interval required to tell disease from deed. The virus imposes that condition on everyone; the rest of the film tests whether the interval can be recovered.

CHAPTER TWO

THE SCREEN AND THE APE

Media, Primates, and Replicative Violence

> *For the life of the flesh is in the blood.*
>
> LEVITICUS 17:11 (KJV)

02



The prologue answers the question of origin twice, and the two answers do not agree. Rage comes from screens and it comes from blood; it is learned and it is caught. This chapter argues that the film fuses a semiotic causality with a somatic one in order to isolate a third thing: a violence that is neither learned nor inherited but replicated.

2.1 The Ludovico inversion

THE film's first spectator is a chimpanzee. Restrained and wired, it faces a bank of monitors relaying documentary footage of riot and atrocity. The image inverts the Ludovico Technique of Burgess and Kubrick, in which Alex, strapped down with his eyelids clamped open and his body dosed with a nausea-inducing drug, is made to watch filmed violence until he can no longer act it. Ludovico conditions aversion to violence; the Cambridge laboratory exposes an ape to violence while studying a disease of rage. The film never explains what the screens are for—inducement, measurement, or the incidental decor of an experiment—and that silence is productive. It lets the image and the pathogen stand side by side as rival theories of origin.

The rivalry had a precise British context. Kubrick withdrew *A Clockwork Orange* from British distribution in 1973 amid claims of imitative crimes, and it did not return to British cinemas until 2000. The "video nasties" campaign of the early 1980s produced the Video Recordings Act of 1984. After the murder of the two-year-old James Bulger in 1993, press speculation tied the killing to *Child's Play* 3, and Parliament added a test of potential harm to the classification regime in 1994. In British public life, the hypothesis that violent images infect had been argued for two decades by tabloids, judges, and legislators. The film literalizes the tabloid hypothesis and then hands the infection to an ape rather than a child. It also refuses to let the image act alone. Rage requires blood. The screen supplies the scene; the body supplies the vector.

2.2 Liberation as transmission

The prologue's first transmission is caused by compassion. Animal-liberation activists break into the laboratory, and one of them opens a cage while the scientist begs them to listen. The context was not abstract in 2002. Peter Singer's *Animal Liberation* (1975) and Richard Ryder's coinage "speciesism" (1970) had given the movement its philosophy; the Animal Liberation Front, founded in Britain in 1976, had given it a direct-action wing; and from 1999 the

campaign Stop Huntingdon Animal Cruelty targeted a contract-testing laboratory in Cambridgeshire. Cambridge University's plan for a primate research centre drew sustained opposition in the same years and was abandoned in 2004. The film does not satirize the activists. It stages them as the first failure of *mora*. Like Aristotle's hasty servants, they act before hearing the whole instruction.

The mythic analogue is Pandora. In Hesiod's *Works and Days* (90–104), she lifts the lid of the jar and releases the evils that now wander among men. Diseases, Hesiod adds, come upon mortals by day and by night of their own accord, *automatoi*, and in silence, because Zeus took away their voice. The Infected are Hesiod's diseases made flesh: self-moving and voiceless, screaming but never speaking. Only Elpis, Hope, remains under the jar's lip. The film's final image will give that remainder a voice.

2.3 Two aggressions

Chimpanzees were not an innocent choice. Between 1974 and 1978 Jane Goodall's team at Gombe recorded the males of the Kasakela community systematically killing the members of the breakaway Kahama group, the first documented coalitionary war among non-human primates (Goodall 1986). Frans de Waal's *Chimpanzee Politics* (1982) described the coalitions, betrayals, and reconciliations of the Arnhem colony, and Richard Wrangham and Dale Peterson's *Demonic Males* (1996) argued that human warfare continues an evolutionary pattern of male coalitionary violence shared with chimpanzees. Donna Haraway's *Primate Visions* (1989) had already warned that primatology is a mirror in which Western culture reads its own narratives of nature and society. Darwin's chapter on hatred and anger in *The Expression of the Emotions* (1872) supplies the oldest layer of that mirror: in rage the face reddens, the eyes glisten, and the lip retracts from the canine, a vestige, Darwin suggested, of fanged ancestors. The Infected's snarl is Darwin's vestige switched back on.

Wrangham's later synthesis gives the film its sharpest scientific gloss. *The Goodness Paradox* (2019) distinguishes reactive aggression—hot, impulsive, a response to provocation—from proactive aggression—cold, planned, and often coalitionary. Chimpanzees are high in both; humans are unusually low in the first and unusually high in the second. Wrangham proposes that humans domesticated themselves through an "execution hypothesis": coalitions of men, able to conspire through language, killed aggressive bullies and so bred out reactive aggression, while sharpening the capacity for planned, collective killing. The film is an uncannily exact dramatization. The chimpanzee virus delivers reactive aggression in pure form. The humans who survive it are proactive aggressors: they plan, conspire, and execute. The first execution of an uninfected man that the film shows is coalitionary, but its victim is not a

bully. Sergeant Farrell is killed for refusing to join the planned rape. The mechanism of self-domestication runs backward, killing the restrained man to protect the conspiracy—a de-domestication.

William Golding had dramatized the same paradox in *The Inheritors* (1955), whose Neanderthals are exterminated by "new people" capable of planning, symbol, and cruelty; the novel's last chapter shifts to the newcomers' point of view. Golding and Garland share a refusal of the flattering hierarchy. The more advanced creature is the more lethal planner, and the ape is the lesser threat.

2.4 The medium is the virus

The screens also place the film inside a theoretical idiom in which the virus had become the master metaphor of media. Marshall McLuhan's claim that the medium is the message (1964) made transmission itself the content of communication. William S. Burroughs figured the word as a virus (*The Ticket That Exploded*, 1962; *The Electronic Revolution*, 1970). Richard Dawkins coined the meme as a replicator of culture (1976) and later described religions as "viruses of the mind" (1993). Jean Baudrillard's *The Transparency of Evil* (1990) diagnosed a "viral" proliferation in which images, signs, and pathogens reproduce without reference. Antonin Artaud had given the metaphor its most violent form in "The Theatre and the Plague," a 1933 lecture published in *The Theatre and Its Double* (1938): like the plague, theatre releases dormant images of cruelty and extends them into the most extreme gestures.

Cinema has repeatedly literalized the idiom. In David Cronenberg's *Videodrome* (1983) a broadcast signal grows a tumor. In Hideo Nakata's *Ringu* (1998) a cursed videotape kills its viewer unless he copies it and shows it to someone else: survival requires transmission, which is the logic of replication stated as ethics. In Stephen King's *Cell* (2006), dedicated to Richard Matheson and George Romero, a signal over mobile phones turns users into a frenzied mass. In Bruce McDonald's *Pontypool* (2008), adapted from Tony Burgess, the infection travels through the English language itself, lodging in terms of endearment, and can be broken only by unmaking meaning: "kill" must be made to mean "kiss." *28 Days Later* stands at the point where the media virus becomes literal again. The screens in its laboratory are a culture medium in the bacteriological sense—the agar in which violence is grown—as well as a media culture. The film's claim is that the two senses have converged.

2.5 Communion without communication

René Girard read plague as the mythic figure of social undifferentiation. In *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) mimetic rivalry erodes the differences that structure society until a sacrificial crisis is resolved by collective violence against a scapegoat; in "The Plague in Literature and Myth" (1974) he showed

epidemic standing for that crisis from Sophocles' Thebes to Artaud and Camus. Blood is the crisis's ambiguous medium: impure violence pollutes, and sacrificial violence purifies. The Infected complicate the scheme. They are perfectly undifferentiated, yet they never fight one another. Their violence involves no rivalry, no shared object of desire, and therefore no mimesis. It is contagion without imitation, a post-mimetic crowd. In Girardian terms they are the sacrificial crisis without the crisis: a peace of the identical, maintained by the destruction of everything non-identical.

The film's Christian frame sharpens the point. "This is my blood," runs the eucharistic formula (Matthew 26:28), and the Church is the body made one by sharing it. Leviticus forbids the eating of blood because life is in the blood (17:10–14). The Infected violate the oldest of dietary taboos and form a parody of the mystical body: one blood, one fury, no persons. Their union is communion without communication. Mary Douglas (1966) defined dirt as matter out of place, and Julia Kristeva (1980) located horror in the abject that crosses the body's borders; the film's vectors are blood out of place—in an eye, in a mouth.

> *"Their union is communion without communication.*

2.6 Replicative violence

Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) divides violence into law-making and law-preserving forms, both of which he calls mythic, and sets against them a divine violence that destroys law, expiates, and strikes without bloodshed. Rage fits none of these. It founds no order and preserves none, and it is all blood. Its only end is its own reproduction. This thesis names it *replicative violence*. Benjamin also asked whether violence could be avoided altogether, and answered that it could through "pure means"—courtesy, trust, conversation—and above all through language, a sphere of human agreement, he wrote, wholly inaccessible to violence. Replicative violence is the dark twin of that answer. It too is a pure means, a means without end in Giorgio Agamben's phrase (1996), but what it transmits is only its own transmissibility.

Two pure media therefore face each other across the film: the virus, which transmits nothing but transmission, and the greeting, which communicates nothing but communicability. They are symmetrical in form and opposite in one respect only, alterity. Replicative violence makes the other the same; address leaves the other other. Greek myth had already given replicative

violence an image. Each severed head of the Lernaean Hydra grows two more, and Heracles, once the stumps are cauterized, dips his arrows in the monster's venom. The weaponized poison returns through the blood of Nessus to destroy him in Sophocles' *Women of Trachis*. Replicative violence, once armed, comes home to its user—the shape of autoimmunity examined in Chapter Four. Table 1 sets out the film's economy of violence in these terms; Chapter Seven adds its temporal axis.

TABLE 1 *The economy of violence in 28 Days Later*

MODE	BEARER IN THE FILM	RELATION TO LAW (AFTER BENJAMIN)	MYTHIC ANALOGUE	COMPARATORS
REACTIVE	The Infected	Outside law; founds and preserves nothing	Lyssa; the berserkers	Romero's *The Crazies*; Cronenberg's *Rabid*
IMMUNITARY	Selena's early rule	Preserves the group by killing its members	The Greeks abandoning Philoctetes on Lemnos	*28 Weeks Later*'s Code Red
PROACTIVE-SOVEREIGN	West and his soldiers	Law-making: founds an order on force	Agamemnon's camp; Odysseus's suitors	Wells's artilleryman; Romero's *Day of the Dead*
HEROIC	Jim in the storm	Law-destroying in function, mythic in form	Cú Chulainn's *riastrad*; Odysseus in the hall	*Straw Dogs*; *Witchfinder General*
REPLICATIVE	The virus itself	None: it reproduces without founding or preserving	The Hydra	*Ringu*; *Pontypool*

CHAPTER THREE

DEAD LONDON

The Sleeper, the Last Man, and the Phatic Void

> *the searchers of the town,*
> *Suspecting that we both were in a house*
> *Where the infectious pestilence did reign,*
> *Seal'd up the doors, and would not let us forth;*
> *So that my speed to Mantua there was stay'd.*

SHAKESPEARE, *ROMEO AND JULIET* 5.2

03



Jim's walk through emptied London is the film's most celebrated sequence, and its meaning is phatic before it is visual. A man calls "Hello?" into a city that cannot answer. This chapter reads the sequence as the opening of an interval that the rest of the film must close: between a call that receives no reply and a call that does.

3.1 The sleeper wakes

JIM wakes naked in a hospital bed at St Thomas', a drip still in his arm, the ward deserted. He dresses in scrubs, drinks, and crosses Westminster Bridge into a capital emptied of people. The scene has an epic ancestor. Odysseus, set down asleep on Ithaca by the Phaeacian sailors, wakes in a homeland that Athena has veiled in mist, and asks the question Homeric heroes ask on every unknown shore: to the land of what mortals have I come—are they violent, savage, and unjust, or kind to strangers, with god-fearing minds? (*Od.* 13.200–202; compare 6.119–21). The sleeper's waking is an interrogation of hospitality. Jim's "Hello?" is the Odyssean formula reduced to a single word.

The device has a modern genealogy. Washington Irving's Rip Van Winkle (1819) sleeps through a revolution; H. G. Wells's sleeper (1899) wakes into a dystopian London two centuries on; Wyndham's Bill Masen wakes in hospital with his eyes bandaged after a triffid sting and so escapes the blindness that has struck everyone else. Masen is saved by not seeing, and Jim is saved by not being conscious. Garland internalized the device in his illustrated novel *The Coma* (2004), and the comic *The Walking Dead* (2003) opened with a coma patient waking alone in a hospital within a year of the film's release. The sleeper is the one subject who experiences catastrophe as discontinuity rather than process. Exempted from the event, he becomes its interpreter and the audience's proxy.

Jim's nakedness also matters. He enters the film as what Lear calls "unaccommodated man," a "poor, bare, forked animal," and as what Agamben (1995) calls bare life: biological existence kept alive by an institution of care. The National Health Service ward has been abandoned by the institution that sustained it. Biopolitics has outlived the state that exercised it, leaving a patient with nobody to administer him.

3.2 Last men and cosy catastrophes

The sequence draws on the Last Man tradition that runs from Jean-Baptiste Cousin de Grainville's *Le Dernier Homme* (1805) to Mary Shelley's *The Last Man* (1826), whose narrator, Lionel Verney, survives a plague and ends writing in Rome for readers who do not exist. Shelley's ending is the negative of the film's. Verney writes to no one; the film's survivors will write to anyone. Daniel Defoe's *A Journal of the Plague Year* (1722) supplies London's historical memory of shut-up houses, watchmen, and searchers. Wells's "Dead London," a late chapter of *The War of the Worlds* (1898), supplies the image: the narrator walks through empty streets toward an inhuman cry, "Ulla, ulla," a howl without address. Wells's Martians are then killed by terrestrial bacteria; humanity is saved by the immunity of its world. The film declines that ending. Its survivors are saved not by immunity but by address.

Brian Aldiss (1973) called Wyndham's mode the "cosy catastrophe": the middle-class hero enjoys the emptied world, with free shops and open roads, while the masses conveniently perish. The film quotes the cosy moment and limits it. Its survivors' supermarket spree is an idyll of plenty that the journey north will end. John Christopher's *The Death of Grass* (1956) is the anti-cosy precedent, and the more exact one. A plant virus kills the world's grasses, and a decent family travels north toward a sheltered valley; within days the decent father has become a warlord. The film's road north retraces Christopher's route. The BBC supplied the rest of the British imaginary: Terry Nation's *Survivors* (1975–77), in which a plague leaves scattered survivors to rebuild; Peter Watkins's *The War Game* (1965), withheld from broadcast for twenty years; and *Threads* (1984), set in Sheffield, which taught a generation that the state's promises of protection were fictions. The most important precedent is Nigel Kneale's *Quatermass and the Pit* (BBC 1958–59; Hammer 1967). An ancient craft unearthed in London awakens a race memory of insectile purges and drives the population into a collective frenzy of killing. Violence, for Kneale, is a residue of non-human origins reactivated by a signal. The film is Kneale's heir more than Romero's.

3.3 "Hello?"

Jim's first word in the empty city is "Hello?", repeated across the bridge and through the streets. Bronisław Malinowski (1923) named the kind of utterance this is. Phatic communion, he wrote, is speech in which "ties of union are created by a mere exchange of words." Roman Jakobson (1960) made the phatic one of language's six functions: utterances that establish, prolong, or test contact, whose example is "Hello, do you hear me?" A phatic call says nothing about the world. It asks whether the channel exists, and with it the community

that the channel presupposes. In an emptied city the call becomes a test of society itself.

The city answers twice. First comes silence, the phatic void. Then comes the first reply, in a church, from a priest who is infected. The Infected are the one population that answers every call, instantly and without fail, but they answer with transmission instead of reply. Malinowski's ties of union are replaced by ties of blood. Three phatic acts organize the narrative. Jim's call is answered by contagion. The soldiers' looped broadcast promises protection to any listener and is answered by survivors who become prey. The HELLO of the ending is answered by rescue. The middle term is the corrupted phatic: an address that does not leave the other as other, but captures it. The film's whole action lies in the interval between an unanswered "Hello?" and an answered HELLO.

3.4 Hysteresis

Crossing the city, Jim stoops to gather banknotes from the pavement. Georg Simmel's *Philosophy of Money* (1900) described money as the most perfect instrument of reciprocity, a crystallized trust whose value rests on the continued existence of society. Without society, the notes are paper. Jim's gesture is what Pierre Bourdieu called hysteresis: the persistence of dispositions in a field that no longer exists. In 1987 Margaret Thatcher told *Woman's Own* that "there is no such thing as society," only individual men and women and families. The film runs that proposition to its limit. What remains when society is subtracted is not a market of individuals but a pair of scavenging strangers, a father and daughter in a tower block, and a house of armed men.

Around the statue at Piccadilly Circus, Jim finds a wall of notices: photographs of the missing, messages to relatives, addresses to people who may be dead. For audiences of 2002 and 2003 it could not fail to recall the missing-persons posters of lower Manhattan in September 2001. Its iconography is also older and stranger. The statue universally called Eros, Alfred Gilbert's Shaftesbury Memorial of 1893, in fact represents Anteros, god of requited love—love defined by its reply. The wall of unanswered addresses has gathered under the god of answered love. No image in the film states its theory more compactly.

> *"The wall of unanswered addresses has gathered under the god of answered love.*

3.5 Sanctuary

Jim enters a church whose floor is heaped with bodies. Thucydides recorded that during the Athenian plague the sacred places were filled with corpses, as men ceased to distinguish the holy from the profane (2.52); Lucretius closed *De Rerum Natura* with the same image. On the church wall an apocalyptic graffito promises the imminent end, intensified by an obscene infix. The priest who rises to attack Jim belongs to a director who has spoken of an adolescent vocation to the priesthood, and the scene's charge is sacramental. The Church is the body made one by blood; the Infected are its parody. The priest's assault is the anti-benediction of a congregation joined in communion without communication.

The graffito also fixes the film's relation to eschatology. In Romero's *Dawn of the Dead*, a character recalls the saying that when there is no more room in hell, the dead will walk the earth. Romero's cycle is eschatological, structured by an end that has already arrived. Garland's end is only "nigh." The film is a nosology, and nosologies have courses rather than ends.

3.6 The digital witness and the infected island

The film was shot largely on Canon XL1 digital video by Anthony Dod Mantle, who had photographed Thomas Vinterberg's Dogme 95 film *Festen* (1998). Its low-resolution image associates it with the media of the prologue: news footage, closed-circuit surveillance, home video. André Bazin (1945) described the photograph as the embalming of time, "change mummified." The digital video image is a degraded index, closer to the surveillance feed than to the death mask; the film's image is itself infected by the screens of its first scene. The empty streets were filmed at dawn, with traffic held back for minutes at a time, so the absence they record is real. The closing sequence, reportedly shot on 35mm film, gives the image a convalescence of its own.

The fiction condensed the epidemiological experience of Britain in the preceding six years. In March 1996 the government acknowledged a probable link between bovine spongiform encephalopathy and a new variant of Creutzfeldt-Jakob disease, and the European Union banned exports of British beef. In 2001 foot-and-mouth disease led to the slaughter of millions of animals; pyres burned across the countryside, footpaths closed, and the general election was postponed by a month. The tabloid press of the 1990s, meanwhile, made rage a national category, popularizing "road rage," "air rage," and their successors; Kenneth Noye's killing of Stephen Cameron at an M25 interchange in 1996 became the emblem. The film fuses all three—a zoonosis, a rage epidemic, a sealed and burning countryside—into one fiction. Britain had already been, in 2001, a country whose meat was refused abroad and whose

fields were closed and on fire. The quarantine the film imagines was a projection from experience.

CHAPTER FOUR

IN A HEARTBEAT

Immunity, Decision, and the Pharmakon

> *Ira furor brevis est: animum rege, qui nisi paret, imperat.* (“Anger is a brief madness: rule your mind, which commands unless it obeys.”)
>
> HORACE, *EPISTLES* 1.2.62–63

04

Selena's rule is the film's first political philosophy, and it is correct. Given an incubation of ten to twenty seconds, an infected companion must be killed at once. This chapter argues that the rule's correctness is exactly its danger: to defeat Rage, it adopts Rage's tempo, and so converts the human decision into a reflex.

4.1 The rule

In the Deptford house where Jim has found his parents dead, the Infected break in at night and Mark is wounded. Selena kills him with a machete in seconds. She then tells Jim that she would do the same to him, "in a heartbeat." Her accompanying doctrine is that plans are pointless and that staying alive is as much as anyone can hope for. The rule and the doctrine form an ethics without a future. It has one maxim, the pre-emptive elimination of the infected intimate, and one horizon, the next few seconds.

The rule's shape is temporal before it is moral. The virus converts its host in ten to twenty seconds, so the rule must act faster than the virus. A defense whose speed is set by its threat has taken its threat as its model. Selena's heartbeat is Rage's heartbeat. Ancient tragedy knew the exclusion of the wounded comrade. In Sophocles' *Philoctetes* (409 BCE) the Greeks abandon their companion on Lemnos because his festering wound, its stench and his cries, made sacrifice impossible. Selena's rule radicalizes that exclusion. It does not maroon the wounded; it kills him.

> *Selena's heartbeat is Rage's heartbeat.*

4.2 Immunitas

Roberto Esposito's trilogy—*Communitas* (1998), *Immunitas* (2002), *Bíos* (2004)—supplies the vocabulary the rule requires. *Communitas* derives from *cum* and *munus*, a gift that is also an obligation and an office. Community is constituted by a debt, by what its members owe one another and must give. *Immunitas* is exemption from *munus*, the condition of owing nothing. Modern politics, for Esposito, is immunitary through and through. From Hobbes onward it protects life by negating it: the subject surrenders natural freedom to the sovereign in exchange for security, as the body receives a fragment of

disease in exchange for resistance. The paradigm turns lethal when protection becomes the destruction of what it protects, a limit Esposito finds in the biopolitics of the twentieth century.

Selena's rule is immunity at the scale of a handful of people. The group protects itself by standing ready to kill any member exposed to infection. It survives on the condition that no one in it is owed anything. The film does not refute the rule as a calculation; epidemiologically, it is sound. What the film measures is its cost. The rule maintains a group that is no longer a community, a *communitas* without *munus*. The gift it withholds will reappear, in the climax, as a kiss.

4.3 Micro-sovereignty and the madness of decision

"Sovereign is he who decides on the exception," Carl Schmitt wrote (1922). Selena's rule distributes sovereignty to every survivor. Each must decide, at any moment, who has become the exception and must die. The status of the infected companion matches what Giorgio Agamben (1995), reviving an archaic figure of Roman law, called *homo sacer*: a life that may be killed without the killing counting as homicide or as sacrifice. Mark dies without crime and without rite. Under the rule, every survivor is potentially *homo sacer* to every other. The state of exception is generalized to the scale of the encounter.

Jacques Derrida's "Force of Law" (1990) explains why this is not yet a decision. A decision that merely applies a rule, Derrida argues, is a calculation; a just decision must pass through the undecidable, and he cites Kierkegaard's dictum that "the instant of decision is a madness." Selena's rule is designed to remove that madness by making the decision automatic. But an automatic response to a stimulus is a reflex, and reflex is the Infected's mode of being. The rule converts the human decision into the very thing it fights. The madness of decision has to be reinstated, not abolished, and Chapter Six will show the film reinstating it in a single hesitation.

The rule also acquired an uncanny context. *The National Security Strategy of the United States*, published in September 2002, committed the United States to act pre-emptively against threats before they were fully formed. The film opened in Britain six weeks later, and in America three months after the invasion of Iraq in March 2003. Ron Suskind (2006) later attributed to Vice President Cheney the principle that a one percent chance of catastrophe must be treated as a certainty. Selena's rule is the one-percent doctrine of the survivor band. The relation is a constellation, not an allegory: the film was written before the doctrine, and recognized it.

4.4 Pharmakon

Selena carries the group's pharmacy. In West's house she gives Hannah pills to dull her consciousness of what the soldiers intend. Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) traced the Greek *pharmakon*, at once remedy and poison, and its cognate *pharmakos*, the scapegoat expelled to purify the city. Selena administers both kinds of *pharmakon*. The machete is a remedy that kills; the sedative is a mercy that anesthetizes an atrocity. Primo Levi's "grey zone" (1986) names the compromised agency of victims forced to take part in the machinery of their oppression, and the scene in which Selena drugs Hannah belongs to it. In her hands protection and harm become indistinguishable, a second lyssic indistinction running parallel to the first. Her arc moves from the *pharmakon*, the measured dose, to the *munus*, the gift without measure.

4.5 Locked doors

Thomas Hobbes's state of nature, in the thirteenth chapter of *Leviathan* (1651), has "no Arts; no Letters; no Society," and the life of man in it is "solitary, poore, nasty, brutish, and short." Hobbes anticipated the objection that this is speculation and answered with an observation: when a man goes to sleep he locks his doors, and even in his own house he locks his chests. The film opens in a world whose doors stand open—Jim walks unchallenged through hospital and city—and then stages locking without end: shutters, barricades, the gates of West's house. Yet its Hobbesian world contains letters. The notes on the wall at Piccadilly are letters written in the war of all against all, addressed to the missing. They prove that address survives the collapse of the commonwealth. The film's last letters, laid out in cloth, will be the first act of a new society.

Rousseau answered Hobbes in the *Discourse on Inequality* (1755): natural man is solitary but peaceable, moved by pity, a natural repugnance at the suffering of a sentient being. Hobbes, Rousseau objected, had projected the passions of civil man into nature. The Infected are neither Hobbesian nor Rousseauian. They seek neither gain, safety, nor glory, and they feel no pity. They are post-natural. Among the survivors the debate is distributed between characters. Selena begins as a Hobbesian. Frank is a Rousseauian who signals to strangers with flashing Christmas lights from his tower block and welcomes those who answer. His lights are the first successful phatic act in the film.

The oldest version of the wolf proverb clarifies the stakes. Hobbes's dedication to *De Cive* (1642) set *homo homini Deus* against *homo homini lupus*, and Freud repeated the second half in *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930). Both quote only half a line. In Plautus's *Asinaria* a merchant, refusing to hand money to a stranger, says *lupus est homo homini, non homo, quom qualis sit non novit*: a man is a wolf to man, not a man, when he does not know what sort the

other is (495). The wolf is not human nature; it is an epistemic condition, the condition of not knowing the other. The Infected abolish the time in which knowing could happen. The film dramatizes Plautus's suppressed clause.

4.6 Autoimmunity and reverse quarantine

Michel Foucault (1975) distinguished two models of power over disease. The leper was excluded: a binary division between pure and impure, enforced by banishment. The plague town was partitioned: every street inspected and every house surveyed, the model from which disciplinary society grew. Selena's rule is the plague model miniaturized, a perpetual inspection of companions for wounds. The quarantine of Britain, revealed in the film's third act, is the leper model at national scale. The island is excluded whole. Britain becomes the leper.

Susan Sontag (1978; 1989) urged that the military metaphors of illness—invasion, defense, the war on disease—be retired. The film literalizes them instead. Its army is the disease's companion, an immune system turned on the body it guards. Derrida's late work generalized the term for this. Autoimmunity, in "Faith and Knowledge" (1996) and *Rogues* (2003), is the process by which a living being works to destroy its own protections; Derrida read the attacks of September 2001, carried out by men trained in America with American aircraft, as an autoimmune crisis. West's compound keeps Private Mailer, infected, chained in its yard in order to learn how long the Infected take to starve. It holds the disease at its center to master it, and the disease, once released, destroys it. Esposito's vaccine logic has become architecture.

Stephen Arata (1990) read *Dracula* as a fantasy of reverse colonization, in which the periphery invades the imperial metropolis. The film inverts the inversion. Britain is not invaded; it is the source, and the world seals the island. Quarantine was born of sea trade: Ragusa (Dubrovnik) required arrivals from plague regions to wait thirty days apart in 1377, and Venice opened its island lazaretto in 1423, its forty-day *quarantena* giving the practice its name. The film's twenty-eight days stand in the same numerology as the *trentino* and the *quarantena*, a waiting period measured by the moon. Gaunt praised England as a fortress built by Nature against infection, its sea serving "as a moat defensive to a house." In *28 Days Later* the moat defends everyone else from England. That is reverse quarantine: the island's defining protection has become its isolation ward.

CHAPTER FIVE

THE HOUSE OF PROSPERO

Sovereignty, Normality, and the Traffic in Women

> *The external world could take care of itself. In the meantime it was folly to grieve, or to think.*
>
> EDGAR ALLAN POE, "THE MASQUE OF THE RED DEATH" (1842)

05



West's compound answers the question Chapter Four left open: what happens when immunity is given time? The rule of the heartbeat permitted no plans. West has nothing but plans. This chapter reads his house as the convergence of a long genealogy of armed camps, and argues that its organizing principle is not survival but reproduction by force.

5.1 The broadcast as lure

THE survivors are drawn north by a looped radio message from soldiers near Manchester, promising protection and a solution to infection to anyone who can reach them. The broadcast is a phatic act of a peculiar kind: an unconditional address that conceals a condition. It is the inverse of the film's final HELLO. John Bunyan's *The Pilgrim's Progress* (1678) supplies the allegory. Christian and Hopeful are imprisoned in Doubting Castle by Giant Despair until Christian remembers a key called Promise that opens every lock. West's broadcast is a counterfeit Promise, a key that locks. The *Odyssey* supplies the myth. The Sirens promise knowledge to every passing sailor, and around them lie heaps of bones (*Od.* 12.39–46); Odysseus hears them safely only because he is bound to the mast. He listens without approaching, a technique of *mora*. The survivors, unbound, approach.

At the abandoned blockade outside Manchester the promise fails twice. No one is there, and Frank, raging at the empty roadblock, is infected by a drop of blood that falls into his eye from a crow feeding on a corpse. Soldiers arrive and shoot him. Only then do they take Jim, Selena, and Hannah to the house.

5.2 "A state of normality"

Major West explains his philosophy to Jim. Since the infection he has seen only "people killing people," which is what he saw in the weeks before it; nothing has changed, and the present is therefore "a state of normality." The speech is the film's most precise inversion of political theory. Walter Benjamin's eighth thesis on the philosophy of history (1940) held that the state of emergency in which the oppressed live is not the exception but the rule, and drew a revolutionary conclusion: the task is to bring about a real state of emergency. West draws the reactionary one. If emergency is normal, nothing is required but business as usual. Robin Wood's formula, in which normality is threatened by the monster, collapses into identity. Normality is the monster.

West reads like a disillusioned student of Freud. In "Thoughts for the Times on War and Death" (1915), Freud argued that war strips away the later

accretions of civilization and lays bare the primal man in each of us, whose unconscious is as murderous as his ancestors'. West also has a contemporary. John Gray's *Straw Dogs*, published in 2002, described humanity as *Homo rapiens* and borrowed James Lovelock's diagnosis of a planetary plague of primates. West is Gray's realism converted into a program. The film's argument against him is that his normality is not observed but organized. He claims to describe a nature that he is in fact producing.

> *Normality is the monster.*

Hannah Arendt's *On Violence* (1970) gives that argument its theory. Power and violence are opposites: power springs from people acting in concert, while violence can destroy power but never create it. West has lost power. His men are demoralized, and one has tried to kill himself. What remains is violence, and West tries to manufacture power from it by a promise.

5.3 Leviathan at table

Max Weber defined the state as the human community that successfully claims the monopoly of legitimate physical force within a territory (1919). West's compound is the state reduced to that definition: a territory (a fortified country house), a monopoly of force (rifles), a claim to legitimacy (rank and uniform), and nothing else. Weber's definition proves to describe a gang with a radio. The frontispiece of Hobbes's *Leviathan* shows a sovereign whose body is made of his subjects; West's soldiers compose such a body, with West as its head.

The dinner at which the soldiers and their new guests eat at West's table belongs to Norbert Elias. *The Civilizing Process* (1939) traced the sociogenesis of affect control through the history of table manners: forks, napkins, the restraint of the knife. Elias later described "decivilizing spurts" in which such controls collapse. West's table preserves the forms of civility as hysteresis while the affects behind them decivilize. The table is where the coming rape is negotiated in the idiom of hospitality.

5.4 "Women mean a future"

West tells Jim why he has promised his men women. The soldier who tried to kill himself saw no future; West promised him women, because "women mean a future." Lee Edelman's *No Future* (2004) named the ideology at work: reproductive futurism, in which the image of the child justifies the social order's demands on the present. West's version dispenses with sentiment.

Futurity is reproductive capacity seized by force. Michel Foucault (1976) described biopower as the power to make live and let die, which displaced the ancient sovereign right to take life—the Roman father's *vitae necisque potestas*. In West's compound the ancient right returns at the core of the biopolitical promise. Achille Mbembe's necropolitics (2003) defines sovereignty as the capacity to decide who may live and who must die, and the compound exercises that capacity over bodies reduced to their reproductive function.

Arendt supplies the counter-concept. Natality, in *The Human Condition* (1958), is the human capacity to begin something new, rooted in birth and actualized in speech and action, through which we insert ourselves into the world "like a second birth." West confuses natality with reproduction, the beginning of the new with the repetition of the same. The film's ending will propose natality without reproduction: a second birth by word.

One observation organizes this chapter. The Infected never rape. Their violence is sexually indifferent; sexual violence belongs to the sane. Freud's late theory of the drives (1920; 1923) described sadism as a fusion of erotic and destructive drives, and named their separation defusion. The Infected embody destructiveness defused, aggression without erotic admixture. West's men embody the fusion: desire put to the service of domination. The virus purifies violence of desire, and the sane re-eroticize it. Susan Brownmiller's *Against Our Will* (1975) treated rape in war as an instrument of domination; the International Criminal Tribunal for Rwanda's *Akayesu* judgment (1998) recognized rape as an act of genocide; the Yugoslav tribunal's *Kunarac* judgment (2001) convicted men who held women in sexual enslavement at Foča of crimes against humanity. The film places the logic those tribunals named inside an English country house. The soldiers have the women dressed in gowns. Selena drugs Hannah, still a child, to spare her consciousness of what is coming.

5.5 A genealogy of the camp

West's house is the terminus of a long British and classical line. Wells's artilleryman in *The War of the Worlds* plans an underground society that will keep fit women and discard the weak, a eugenic fantasy entertained by a man unwilling to dig. In *The Day of the Triffids* a committee of sighted survivors proposes that each sighted man take several women, sighted and blind, to maximize births, and a later military-feudal regime offers protection in exchange for servitude. In Christopher's *The Death of Grass* a decent family becomes a warband within days. In Romero's *Day of the Dead* soldiers in an underground bunker threaten the scientist Sarah while a doctor keeps a ghoul in chains. In José Saramago's *Blindness* (1995), the blind internees of a quarantine asylum are made to buy food with women by an armed gang, until the one sighted woman kills its leader with scissors.

The genealogy reaches back to the *Iliad*'s first book. Chryseis and Briseis are prizes of honor in an armed camp, and the plague is the price of holding a priest's daughter. Jonathan Shay (1994) read Achilles' wrath as the response of a soldier whose commander has betrayed what is right, and West betrays his own men's sense of what is right as surely as Agamemnon betrays Achilles. Claude Lévi-Strauss (1949) argued that the exchange of women founds kinship and therefore society, and Gayle Rubin's "The Traffic in Women" (1975) turned that argument into a critique. West refounds society on the traffic in its rawest form. Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (1913) imagined a primal horde in which the father monopolizes the women until his sons kill him. West inverts the horde. The father distributes women to his sons to prevent their suicide, buying their loyalty with what Freud's father hoarded. The parricide follows anyway.

5.6 Mailer in chains

Private Mailer, infected, is chained in the yard. Romero's Bub, in *Day of the Dead*, is the obvious precedent. The scientist Logan domesticates his chained ghoul, which learns to salute and then shoots the commander, Rhodes. Mailer is Bub without domestication: a soldier reduced to a measurement device. That Mailer is played by a Black actor, held in chains as a specimen in the grounds of an English country house, lends the image a colonial and plantation resonance that the film neither underlines nor cancels.

Euripides' *Bacchae* supplies the deeper myth. King Pentheus chains the god Dionysus in his stables; the god walks free, the palace shakes, and Pentheus, dressed by the god as a woman, is torn apart by the women of Thebes. West reverses the costume, dressing the women to his own taste, and the chained god-beast will drag him down. Shakespeare offers the last frame. At the end of *The Tempest*, Prospero says of Caliban, "this thing of darkness I / Acknowledge mine" (5.1.275–76). West never acknowledges Mailer as his own. Mailer is the compound's vaccine, the pathogen kept inside to produce knowledge and protection. His name makes him one of the film's carriers, the Mailer beside the courier.

5.7 Hostipitality

Émile Benveniste (1969) showed that Latin *hostis*, the enemy, first meant the stranger with reciprocal rights, the guest, and that *hospes* derives from a compound meaning "master of guests." Derrida (2000) coined "hostipitality" for the aporia that follows: to host is to be master of one's house, so hospitality carries hostility within it. West's house is the hostipitable house par excellence. He welcomes in order to master. In Greek religion Zeus Xenios protects guests, and the violation of hospitality is the gravest crime. The *Odyssey* is an epic of such violations: the Cyclops eats his guests, and the suitors consume an absent

host's house and court his wife. West's house combines the suitors' banquet with the Cyclops's cave. Ovid's Lycaon serves human flesh to his divine guest and is turned into a wolf; the deluge follows. The storm that breaks over West's house in the next chapter answers that sequence.

The literary house supplies the rest. Poe's Prince Prospero welds shut the gates of his castellated abbey against the Red Death and holds a masquerade, until the Red Death enters as a masked guest; its avatar, Poe wrote, was blood. Boccaccio's young Florentines in the *Decameron* fled the plague of 1348 to country villas and told one another stories; West's retreat inverts theirs, replacing narrative with orders. Ben Jonson's "To Penshurst" (1616) praised the English country house as a place of open hospitality where every guest is fed. Kazuo Ishiguro's *The Remains of the Day* (1989) showed the same house's civility as a mask for collaboration. West's house is Penshurst's nightmare.

Joseph Conrad's Kurtz, who ends his report on the suppression of savage customs with "Exterminate all the brutes!", stands behind West, as does Coppola's Colonel Kurtz. The commander's name completes the genealogy. Oswald Spengler's *Der Untergang des Abendlandes* (1918–22) named the West the evening land, *Abendland*, the land of the setting sun. Major West's decline is the decline of the West in its most literal form: a house of armed men, a dinner at a long table, and women in gowns, waiting for night.

CHAPTER SIX

RÍASTRAD

The Storm, the Unchaining, and the Undecidable Face

> *Thou art the thing itself: unaccommodated man is no more but such a poor, bare, forked animal as thou art.*
>
> SHAKESPEARE, *KING LEAR* 3.4





The climax returns *lyssa* to a hero. Jim comes back to West's house through a storm, releases the Infected soldier into it, and kills with his hands. This chapter argues that the film makes his fury formally indistinguishable from the disease, and then resolves the indistinction not by a test of blood but by a look, a hesitation, and a kiss.

6.1 The contrail

TAKEN into the woods to be executed beside Sergeant Farrell, who had refused to join the plan for the women, Jim escapes as Farrell is killed. Farrell had earlier offered him a hypothesis: the infection had never left Britain, and the rest of the world had simply sealed the island off. Now Jim looks up and sees the contrail of a jet crossing the sky. The image does two things at once. It confirms the reverse quarantine, since somewhere beyond the island aircraft still fly. And it voids West's reproductive emergency. The human species is not at risk; there is no future to secure by rape. West's futurism stands exposed as a pretext. The truth arrives as a line written across the sky, a trace, and the reply to the survivors' HELLO will come from the same direction.

6.2 The storm

Jim returns through a thunderstorm. In Genesis the flood answers an earth "filled with violence" (6:11), *ḥāmās*. In Ovid it answers Lycaon's violation of hospitality. In *King Lear* the storm strips a king of his sovereignty and reveals the "poor, bare, forked animal" in Edgar's nakedness. Jim, stripped to the waist and slick with rain and blood, moves from Poor Tom to Achilles. Cinema supplies the closer precedents. In *Apocalypse Now* Willard rises from black water to kill Kurtz, his blows intercut with the ritual slaughter of a water buffalo, assassination staged as sacrifice. In Sam Peckinpah's *Straw Dogs* (1971), a mild mathematician besieged in a Cornish farmhouse discovers a capacity for killing that exhilarates him. In Michael Reeves's *Witchfinder General* (1968), the avenger's axe-blows continue past any purpose while the woman he meant to protect screams. These films treat the hero's vengeance as a contagion of brutality, and the film inherits their ambivalence without resolving it.

6.3 Unchaining

Jim releases Mailer into the house. The hero deploys the pathogen as a weapon; the protagonist wages biological war. Myth anticipated the move. Heracles dipped his arrows in the venom of the Hydra, and the poison returned through the blood of the centaur Nessus to destroy him. The film does not hide that its hero wins by infecting the house. Structurally, Jim repeats the activists of the prologue: he opens the cage. The difference is intention, and the film declines to say whether intention is enough. It is the first sign that Jim's fury will be indistinguishable, at the level of form, from what it fights.

6.4 The warp-spasm

Jim kills soldiers with his bare hands and drives his thumbs into Corporal Mitchell's eyes. This is *ríastrad* in the full sense: the hero's body distorted by fury, returning to a household that cannot safely receive him. Achilles after the death of Patroclus is its Greek form, as *lyssa* holds his heart on the riverbank (*Il.* 21.542–43). Shay's etiology of the berserk state fits Jim precisely: a betrayal by command, in West's violated hospitality, and the loss of a comrade, in Frank. Dumézil's warrior must be reintegrated by rite when he comes home from killing; Jim comes home to a house of strangers, still killing.

John Murphy's score makes the indistinction audible. The cue that drives the climax is titled "In the House – In a Heartbeat": its title names both the place of the violence and Selena's rule, and its pulse binds Jim's heroism to the tempo of immunitary decision. Jim's rescue and the rule of the heartbeat share one rhythm. The cue's later ubiquity in trailers and other films shows how readily the culture consumed the indistinction as exhilaration.

6.5 The ocular economy

The film is organized by eyes. Its first image of the ape is of a creature fixed on screens. The Infected's bloodshot eyes repeat Seneca's blazing eyes, the messenger's account of Heracles, and Darwin's glistening rage. Frank is infected through the eye, by a drop of blood from a crow. Mitchell is blinded. Cú Chulainn's warp-spasm sucks one eye into his skull and thrusts the other onto his cheek. The blinding has a long lineage: Odysseus blinds the Cyclops who ate his guests; Cornwall blinds Gloucester ("Out, vile jelly!", *Lear* 3.7); Oedipus blinds himself in plague-stricken Thebes. Blindness has also been a figure of immunity. Wyndham's Masen survives because his eyes were bandaged, and Saramago's epidemic is itself a blindness. In this film the eye is a *pharmakon*. It is the portal through which infection enters and the organ

through which infection is diagnosed. That is why the climax turns on a single question: what does Selena see?

6.6 The undecidable face

Selena raises her machete over Jim. He is soaked in blood and moving with a fury indistinguishable from the disease; on her own rule, she has seconds to act. She hesitates. In that hesitation the film reverses its entire diagnostic sequence.

Plautus's condition is met: she does not know what sort he is, *qualis sit*. Aristotle's dog is restrained: she does not bark at the knock, but looks to see whether the visitor is a friend. The Odyssean pattern returns. After the slaughter of the suitors, Penelope refuses to acknowledge Odysseus, to the scandal of her son, until she has tested him with the secret of their bed (*Od.* 23). Recognition requires delay, and delay requires accepting the risk that delay entails. Philip K. Dick's empathy test (1968), filmed as the Voight-Kampff machine in *Blade Runner* (1982), reads humanity in the involuntary responses of the eye; Selena performs the test without a machine. Emmanuel Levinas (1961) located the origin of ethics in the face of the other, whose first signification is the prohibition of murder. Aristotle's *anagnorisis*, the change from ignorance to knowledge, is best when it coincides with reversal (*Poetics* 11). Selena's look is both.

Above all, the hesitation reinstates the madness of decision that her rule was designed to abolish. A calculation would have struck. A decision, in Derrida's sense, passes through the undecidable. The heartbeat has become an interval.

> *The heartbeat has become an interval.*

6.7 The kiss

Then they kiss, Jim's face still bloodied. In a world in which blood in the mouth is the surest route of infection, it is the most dangerous act available. It repeats Theseus's gesture in Euripides' *Heracles*. The hero, emerging from frenzy, veils himself so that his pollution will not reach his friend; the friend uncovers him and takes his hand, declaring that no avenging spirit passes between friends. The kiss is Esposito's *munus*, the gift that exposes the giver, offered by the character who had lived by immunity. It is the substitution that *Pontypool* could perform only in language, where "kill" must be made to mean "kiss." Here the substitution is performed on the body.

6.8 Pentheus in the taxi

As they escape, West shoots Jim, and Mailer seizes West. The chained god-beast destroys the king, as Dionysus destroys Pentheus and Bub's bullet finishes Romero's Rhodes. The parricide of Freud's primal horde completes itself. Hannah drives her dead father's taxi. The inheritance passes not through the blood but through the vehicle.

That vehicle deserves a final word. The London black cab is a hackney carriage, and its drivers are legally bound to accept any hiring within a compellable distance: whoever hails a cab must be carried. Frank's taxi is the one British institution of unconditioned carriage, a vehicle of hospitality to strangers by law. The escape is made in it, driven by a child. The carrier that saves the survivors is not blood, not a broadcast, and not a soldier, but a public conveyance obliged to take anyone.

CHAPTER SEVEN

HELL/O

Lunar Time and the Vocative Turn

> *I do set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be for a token of a covenant between me and the earth.*
>
> GENESIS 9:13 (KJV)



The ending is the film's theory. Jim wakes a second time; Selena sews; the survivors lay out a word in cloth for a reader in the sky; the reply arrives in a language they do not speak. This chapter reads each element in turn and closes with a formal statement of phatic anthropogenesis.

7.1 The second waking

JIM wakes again, in a bed in a remote cottage, his wound tended. The shot rhymes with the opening. The first waking was into a world without address; the second is into a world of care. Søren Kierkegaard's *Repetition* (1843) distinguished repetition from recollection: they are the same movement in opposite directions, since what is recollected has been, while genuine repetition is recollected forward. Gilles Deleuze (1968) made repetition the production of difference. Jim's second waking is a repetition in both senses: the same scene received anew, with a different world around it.

The filmed alternate ending sharpens the point by contrast. In it, Jim dies in an abandoned hospital, and Selena and Hannah walk on without him. The alternate makes the second hospital a tomb; the theatrical ending makes the cottage a cradle. Arendt's phrase applies exactly: through word and deed we insert ourselves into the human world, "like a second birth." Jim's second birth will be completed by a word.

7.2 Selene's month

The film's time is lunar. Selena bears the name of Selene, the Moon, who in Greek myth loved Endymion, the shepherd granted eternal sleep; Keats gave the story its English form in *Endymion* (1818). Jim is an Endymion who wakes twice. The title's twenty-eight days approximate a lunar month: the synodic month is about 29.5 days and the sidereal about 27.3, and twenty-eight is the conventional figure for both the lunar and the menstrual cycle. Twenty-eight is also the second perfect number, the sum of its divisors 1, 2, 4, 7, and 14, and the seventh triangular number, the sum of the integers from one to seven: four weeks of seven days. It is the standard length of residential rehabilitation, which Betty Thomas's *28 Days* (2000) had made a film title two years earlier. In every register the number measures a cycle of recurrence and recovery, not an end.

Frank Kermode's *The Sense of an Ending* (1967) argued that Western fictions organize time by their ends, as the tock that gives meaning to the tick. Apocalyptic narrative makes the interval meaningful by its conclusion. The film's lunar structure makes the end a phase, and the franchise has followed

that logic, returning at twenty-eight weeks and twenty-eight years. Music confirms it. On the road north the film borrows Brian Eno's "An Ending (Ascent)," from *Apollo: Atmospheres and Soundtracks* (1983), music made for the lunar footage of Al Reinert's *For All Mankind* (1989). An ending that is an ascent, composed for the moon: the cue glosses the film's structure. The constellation even closes on a name. Apollo, the god who sent the plague in the *Iliad*'s first book, lent his name to the program that saw the earth whole from the moon. The film's ending likewise culminates in a view from above, a field read from the sky.

7.3 The web

Selena sews, and the cloth will become the survivors' message. Penelope is the epic's great weaver of delay. She promises the suitors to choose a husband when she has finished a shroud for Laertes, and unweaves each night what she wove by day (*Od.* 2.93–110; 19.137–56; 24.128–48). The web is *mora* made into a technology, the craft that holds violence off by deferring decision. Ovid's Philomela, raped by Tereus and silenced when he cuts out her tongue, weaves her testimony into a tapestry and sends it to her sister (*Metamorphoses* 6.424–674). The textile becomes the voice of the voiceless. The film's women, who escaped West's house, weave not an accusation but a greeting. Philomela's tapestry is converted from testimony to salutation. The Latin *textus* means woven, and the HELLO is a text in the etymological sense.

7.4 O

As a jet approaches, the cloth on the field reads HELL; the survivors lay the final O just in time. Jonathan Culler's "Apostrophe" (1977) identified the O of lyric address as the most embarrassing figure in poetry. It speaks to the absent, the dead, and the inanimate, and presumes a responsiveness it cannot command. Apostrophe, Culler argued, constitutes a relation rather than describing one. The film's O completes HELL into HELLO: the vocative redeems the infernal. The letter is also a zero, a full moon, and an open mouth, the scream of the Infected reshaped as speech.

Dante's gate bids those who enter abandon every hope (*Inferno* 3.9). Romero's saying imagined the dead returning when hell is full. The film writes HELL in order to annul it, and the smallest possible difference, one letter, separates damnation from salutation. The word itself has a lyssic history. "Hallo" and "halloo" were once cries used to urge hounds to the chase, before "hello" became a greeting; Thomas Edison proposed it in 1877 as the word with which to answer the telephone, making it the archetypal word of the channel. The call that once set dogs on the quarry has become the call that greets the stranger. J. L. Austin (1962) classed greeting among the behabitives,

performatives that enact a social relation rather than report a fact. HELLO states nothing. It opens contact.

> *The film's O completes HELL into HELLO: the vocative redeems the infernal.*

7.5 Red Peter's "Hallo"

Kafka's "A Report to an Academy" (1917) is the film's nearest literary relation. Red Peter, an ape captured on the Gold Coast, explains to the learned gentlemen how he became human. He did not seek freedom, only *einen Ausweg*, a way out. Imitating his captors, he learned to drink schnapps, and one night he broke into human speech with a single cry: "Hallo!" With that cry, he reports, he leapt into the human community, the *Menschengemeinschaft*. Kafka's ape enters humanity through a phatic exclamation. The film begins with an ape whose rage infects the human, and ends with a human hello that re-founds the human. It runs Kafka's report in both directions at once.

Giorgio Agamben's *The Open* (2002) describes an "anthropological machine" that produces the human by separating it from the animal within. Linnaeus, Agamben notes, gave *Homo* no distinguishing character in the *Systema Naturae*, only the injunction *nosce te ipsum*: know yourself. The human, on this reading, is the animal that must recognize itself as human in order to be human. Ernst Haeckel (1868) posited a missing link, *Pithecanthropus alalus*, the speechless ape-man. The Infected are Haeckel's creature produced in reverse: humans made speechless.

Here the thesis makes its central reformulation. The film's anthropological machine runs not through reflexive recognition but through the vocative. The human is produced not by knowing oneself but by being addressed and by addressing: not *nosce te ipsum* but *salve*. Recognition happens in the second person, in Selena's look and in the pilot's reading of the field. Roman Jakobson observed that the phatic is the only linguistic function that talking birds share with humans, and the first that infants acquire (1960). The phatic marks the threshold where the human begins. Rousseau, in the *Essay on the Origin of Languages* (1781), held that the first voices were wrung from men not by hunger or thirst but by love, hatred, pity, and anger. The film agrees in a negative register. Anger wrings voices from the Infected, but only screams. The first word of the restored world is a greeting.

7.6 The bow in the cloud

The ending inverts the covenant that closes the Flood. Noah sends out a raven, which goes to and fro and never returns, and then a dove, which comes back with an olive leaf (Genesis 8:7–11). God then sets his bow in the cloud as a token of the covenant, a sign written in the sky and addressed to the earth (9:13). The film keeps the birds and reverses their roles. The crow that infects Frank is Noah's raven turned carrier, kin to the battle-crow of Irish saga that settles on the dying Cú Chulainn's shoulder and to the raven among the Old English beasts of battle. The dove returns as a jet. And the sign is written on the earth for a reader in the sky. The covenant is no longer a divine promise not to destroy, but a human request to be seen: horizontal, humble, and conditional on no one's identity.

7.7 The Finnish reply

The pilot radios in Finnish: *Lähetä helikopteri*, send a helicopter. The survivors cannot understand the words. The reply arrives as action rather than meaning, and its foreignness is its point. At Babel the multiplication of languages was a punishment (Genesis 11). Here it is the sign that the outside world is other and still there. Benjamin's "The Task of the Translator" (1923) held that languages are related not by resemblance but by their shared intention toward what is to be said; the English HELLO and the Finnish reply belong to one intention, address, without sharing one meaning. Kant's cosmopolitan right (1795) is a right of visit, not of guest: the stranger's right not to be treated as an enemy on arrival. The Finnish aircraft exercises that right in reverse, as the outside comes to the quarantined island. Derrida's unconditional hospitality (1997) welcomes the arrivant without asking his name, and HELLO asks no name. The nonviolent sphere of understanding that Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" located in language has its emblem in this exchange, though neither party understands the other's words.

The rescue is not innocent. The aircraft is military, and it belongs to the cordon that has sealed the island. The naval officer who arrives at the end of *Lord of the Flies* (1954) is himself engaged in war, and the boat named *Tomorrow* that emerges from the fog at the end of *Children of Men* (2006) belongs to a project whose nature remains unknown. The film's reply is logistics, not salvation. Gaunt's "silver sea" is crossed by a foreign airman, and the island is addressed from abroad. Readers after the British vote of 2016 to leave the European Union have found this reversal newly pointed, and *28 Years Later* (2025) makes that reading difficult to avoid.

The rejected endings complete the argument. The filmed alternate ends in exhaustion. The storyboarded "radical alternative" ends in sacrifice, a

transfusion in which one man's blood buys another's life. It recalls the transfusions that circulate through *Dracula* (1897) and the sacrificial resolution that Girard placed at the origin of culture. The theatrical film rejects both. It refuses the economy in which one life's blood pays for the community, and chooses one in which the community is a reply.

7.8 Phatic anthropogenesis: a formal statement

The argument can be stated in five propositions.

1. Contagion is assimilative transmission. It converts the other into the same and requires no address. It arrives without being sent.
2. Address is alteritive transmission. It calls the other as other and cannot command its arrival. It is sent without assurance of arriving.
3. The human is not given (as species), inherited (as blood), or conferred (as sovereign decision). It is produced in the interval that address opens, through three acts: a suspended decision, an accepted exposure, an unconditioned call.
4. This production is renewable and never complete. It must be performed again at each encounter, which is why the film's time is lunar and not apocalyptic.
5. The phatic is the minimal form of politics: a polity whose founding act is not the exception but the greeting.

Jacques Lacan held that a letter always arrives at its destination; Derrida replied, in *The Post Card* (1980), that a letter can always fail to arrive. The film takes Derrida's side and draws an ethic from it. Contagion is arrival without address. Greeting is address without guaranteed arrival, and its dignity lies in that risk. The axes of tempo and addressee that run beneath Table 1 can now be drawn together. Table 2 places the film's modes of violence, and its single mode of non-violence, on these two axes.

TABLE 2 *Tempo and addressee in 28 Days Later*

TEMPO	ADDRESSED TO ANYONE	ADDRESSED TO SOMEONE
REFLEX (THE HEARTBEAT)	**Reactive** *the Infected*	**Immunitary and heroic** *Selena's rule; Jim in the storm*
INTERVAL (*MORA*)	**Phatic** *the HELLO*	**Proactive-sovereign** *West's compound*

The table makes the thesis visible at a glance. The phatic shares its unconditionality with the Infected, who also strike anyone, and its patience with the sovereign, who also takes time. It shares the violence of neither. The greeting is the reactive slowed down and the sovereign opened up. And Selena's rule shares its quadrant with Jim's fury, which is why, in the climax, she cannot tell them apart.

CONCLUSION

THE INTERVAL BEYOND THE HEARTBEAT

IN THIS SECTION

01 *Lyssic cinema*

02 *The franchise*

03 *The authors*

04 *The courier's last delivery*

28 Days Later diagnoses violence and prescribes address. Its diagnosis proceeds by institution. The laboratory cultures rage in the name of cure; the screen supplies its scenes; the city collapses into a silence that only the Infected answer; the survivor band preserves itself by adopting the virus's tempo; the sovereign compound preserves itself by keeping the disease in its yard and the women in its rooms; and the island is sealed by the world it once claimed to defend. At each stage the containment reproduces the thing contained. The prescription consists of three counter-reflexes—suspended decision, accepted exposure, unconditioned address—and its emblem is a single letter, the O that turns HELL into HELLO.

Lyssic cinema

THE thesis proposes that the film founds a distinct genre, here called lyssic cinema, whose differences from the zombie film are systematic rather than incidental. The zombie film is eschatological: its monsters are the dead, its event is the end, its politics is the siege, and its affect is dread of the mass. Lyssic cinema is nosological: its monsters are the living sick, its event is an outbreak with a course, its politics is the immunitary decision, and its affect is terror of the encounter, the seconds in which one must decide what the other is. Its central question is not whether one will survive but whether one will recognize.

The definition also locates the thesis within horror studies. Zombie criticism has read the walking dead through theology (Paffenroth 2006), through the American Gothic (Bishop 2010), and as the posthuman figure of a dispossessed labor (Lauro and Embry 2008). Horror theory has defined the monster by its violation of categories (Carroll 1990) and the genre's survivor by her gender (Clover 1992). *28 Days Later* fits these accounts poorly. Its monster violates no category except time, and its survivors are defined by what they do in seconds. Lyssic cinema asks to be read through the theory of decision rather than the theory of category.

> *Its central question is not whether one will survive but whether one will recognize.*

The successors bear the distinction out. In Yeon Sang-ho's *Train to Busan* (2016), soldiers guarding a tunnel prepare to shoot two approaching figures until the child among them sings the song she had prepared for her father; the song persuades them that she is not infected. It is the phatic proof of humanity, Selena's hesitation transferred to an army. In *The Last of Us* (Naughty Dog, 2013; HBO, 2023), Joel kills the surgeons who would sacrifice Ellie for a vaccine: a refusal of sacrificial immunization, though one made in blood and concealed by a lie. In the film of *World War Z* (2013), Jerusalem's wall, the immunitary barrier par excellence, is breached when amplified singing inside it draws the horde. The phatic misfires as a lure, and the hero survives by injecting himself with a curable disease that makes him invisible to the infected—vaccine logic made literal. In *The Girl with All the Gifts* (M. R. Carey 2014; Colm McCarthy 2016), the human future passes to infected children taught through glass by a captive teacher, a community founded by address rather than blood.

The franchise

The sequels test the original's propositions under harsher conditions. *28 Weeks Later* (Juan Carlos Fresnadillo, 2007) opens with Don abandoning his wife Alice to the Infected in a besieged cottage: the anti-Theseus, the man who chooses immunity over the touch. A reconstruction led by the United States repopulates a guarded district on the Isle of Dogs. Alice returns as an asymptomatic carrier, the figure Priscilla Wald (2008) traced through the outbreak narrative from Typhoid Mary onward, and Don's kiss infects him. He kills her with his thumbs in her eyes, the lethal counter-kiss to Jim and Selena's and a repetition of Jim's blinding of Mitchell. The order known as Code Red then instructs snipers to fire on everyone, since they can no longer tell the infected from the healthy. Selena's rule has become military doctrine, and a sniper who refuses to obey inherits Farrell's role. The final shot shows the Infected in Paris: the reverse quarantine has failed. The sequel is the original's antithesis, a test of the phatic that ends in the failure of immunity.

28 Years Later (Boyle and Garland, 2025) returns to the original authors and writes the lunar logic into geography. Its community lives on Holy Island, joined to the mainland by a tidal causeway that opens and closes with the moon. Dr. Kelson's ossuary, the Bone Temple, joins the injunction to remember

death to an injunction to remember love, *memento mori* to *memento amoris*. An infected woman gives birth to an uninfected child: natality surviving the disease. A Swedish soldier, stranded from a passing patrol, confirms that the world beyond the island continues. *28 Years Later: The Bone Temple* (Nia DaCosta, 2026) continues the story beyond the scope of this thesis.

The authors

Garland's films as director return to the original's structures with the persistence of a research program. *Ex Machina* (2014) relocates West's compound to a technologist's isolated house, where a captive woman serves the master, and turns Selena's hesitation into an institution, the Turing test. *Annihilation* (2018) makes contagion creative, a zone that refracts and recombines life, and ends with an embrace whose participants may not be who they seem: recognition made permanently undecidable. *Men* (2022) gives replicative violence its most literal image, as one man gives birth to another in an unbroken chain. *Civil War* (2024) gives the immunitary interrogation its most chilling line, when an armed man asks his captives what kind of American they are. That question is the anti-HELLO, an address designed to sort the living from the killable. *Warfare* (2025), co-directed with Ray Mendoza, returns to the besieged house in real time. Garland also co-wrote the video game *Enslaved: Odyssey to the West* (2010), whose title joins Odysseus to the theme of captivity.

Boyle's trajectory is complementary. *127 Hours* (2010) ends with a man who has amputated his own arm to survive stumbling toward strangers and calling for help, a cry that is answered. His opening ceremony for the London Olympics in 2012, titled *Isles of Wonder*, gave Caliban's "Be not afeard; the isle is full of noises" to an actor playing Isambard Kingdom Brunel. It also celebrated the National Health Service, with nurses and children's hospital beds. A decade after *28 Days Later* abandoned its hero in an empty NHS ward, Boyle filled the ward with dancers. The island of noises and the hospital of care are the two halves of the film's argument, set before the world.

The courier's last delivery

Jim was a courier. His delivery was interrupted by an accident, as Friar John's letter to Romeo was halted by searchers who sealed a house against plague; the tragedy in Verona followed from an undelivered letter. Jim spends the film among carriers: a broadcast, a taxi, a soldier named Mailer, a crow, a wall of notes. At the end he takes part in the only delivery the film believes in, a message with no content except the existence of its addressee. The film begins with a question, "Hello?", which nothing answers except the disease. It ends

with the same word as an address, laid out on the earth and answered from the sky. The infection is never cured. The film ends when the call is answered.

BACK MATTER

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INDEX TERMS

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